VON ZAROVICH ESTATE / STATION 1

The Library

Empty hands. Watchful eyes.

The door sighs shut behind you, stirring a cloud of dust that glitters in the candlelight. Tall bookshelves crowd the walls, their shelves bowed beneath cracked leather volumes. Somewhere among them, a page turns. Neither of you touched a book.

Six stone ancestors stand in shadowed alcoves, their empty hands extended as if expecting gifts. Small nameplates identify Victoria, Alexi, Teresa, Valerius, Borislav, and Barov. Their faces are stern enough to make whispering feel compulsory. Barov stands higher than the others, on a tall plinth.

A rumpled velvet runner covers part of a heavy reading table. Six carved relics rest upon it: a book, a scythe, a dagger, a spear, a hammer, and a crown. Candle flames tremble across their edges. Behind the statues, the Archive Gate remains firmly closed.

Above the fireplace crouches a stone gargoyle. You could swear its eyes follow your hands. A log cracks in the hearth, loud as a snapped bone. For a moment, every statue seems to be waiting for you to make the first move.

What do you do? Talk with your partner. Tell the DM what you want to examine or try. Your character sheet may give you ideas.

The Library — Ancestor Statue

Cut out the 4 × 6 inch card. Place flat or use a card holder.

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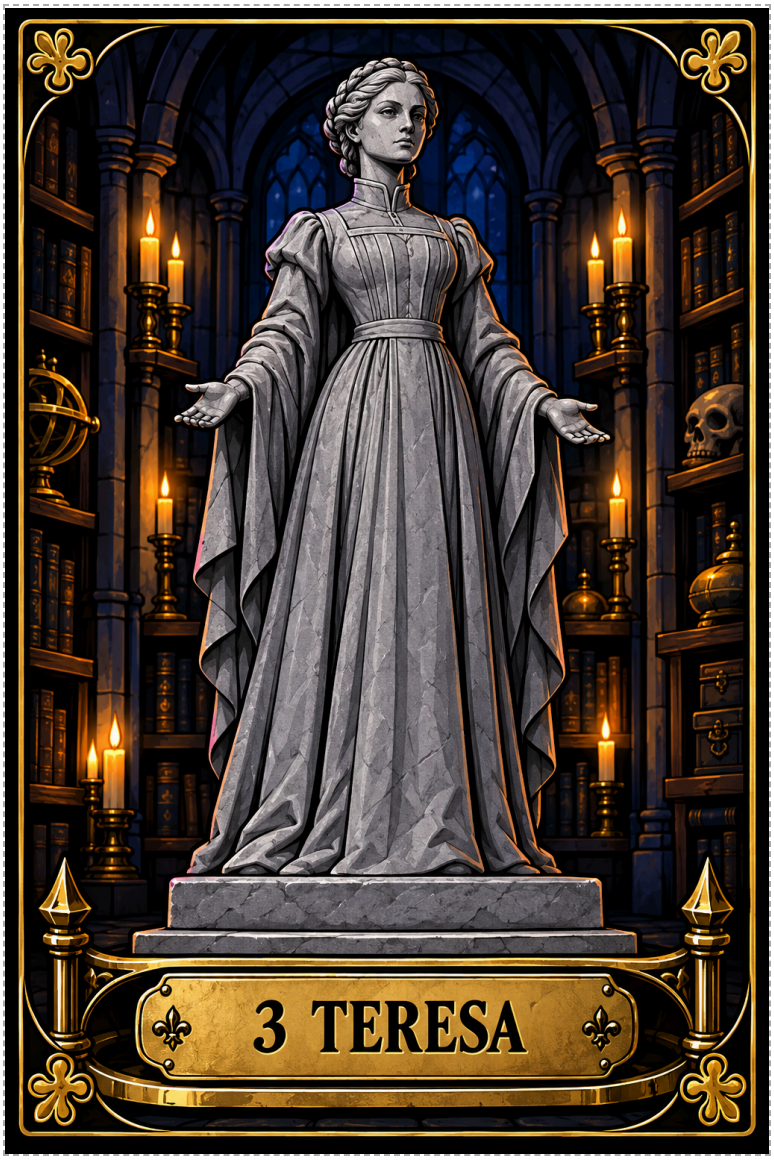

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The Six Stone Relics

Cut the six tokens apart along the white gutters. Each is approximately 2.4 inches square. Lay them on the reading table; place a chosen token beside a statue when making an offering.

The Watcher

Cut along the white silhouette. Mount in a clip or fold the base tab onto a card foot.

DM-held inspection slips

Cut apart before play. Give only the slip earned by inspecting that statue; keep all others hidden.

1 — Victoria

Black ink is ground into her fingertips and thumbs.

2 — Alexi

Dried, flaking mud is caked on his boots and coat hem.

3 — Teresa

Dark crimson stains her palms and the skin under her fingernails.

4 — Valerius

He smells of salt and brine. Tiny barnacles cling to his shoulder plates.

5 — Borislav

Black soot smears his jaw, knuckles and forearms.

6 — Barov

Nothing. No stain, no grime, not even dust. He gleams as if polished this morning.

DM-held progressive clues

Reading table: reveal at minute 2–3 if needed, or when the runner is lifted. Cut the art apart from these instructions.

Plinth plate: reveal at minute 8–9, automatically by 9:00.

DM-held reward and encounter

Archive Crest #1

Spectre

Give the crest only when all six relics are matched. Reveal the Spectre only after the crown/dagger taboo swap. Cut its silhouette and mount in a clip or on a folded base.

Full-title labels — reveal after success

Arch-Librarian Victoria	Lord Alexi the Harvester
Lady Teresa the Traitor	Admiral Valerius
Forge-Master Borislav	King Barov the Spotless

Keep these separate until solved. Do not print titles on the backs of player cards where they might be seen early.

DM ONLY — Library answer & running sheet

Statue	Evidence	Relic
1 Victoria	Black ink is ground into her fingertips and thumbs.	Book
2 Alexi	Dried, flaking mud is caked on his boots and coat hem.	Scythe
3 Teresa	Dark crimson stains her palms and the skin under her fingernails.	Dagger
4 Valerius	He smells of salt and brine. Tiny barnacles cling to his shoulder plates.	Spear
5 Borislav	Black soot smears his jaw, knuckles and forearms.	Hammer
6 Barov	Nothing. No stain, no grime, not even dust. He gleams as if polished this morning.	Crown

Setup & inspection

Place six statues and relic tokens; raise Barov on a small box or book. Put the gargoyle above the table. Hide slips, inscriptions, full titles, Spectre and crest.

Investigation DC 13: Fred +4, Griffin +5. Success earns the detail slip. Failure invites a new approach next turn; never lock out the clue. Barov needs no roll on a close inspection (Mage Hand, climb, or close study after Clue 3).

Character hooks

Fred: once this station, Let's Split Up gives both partners advantage inspecting different statues. Griffin: invisible, so immune to the gargoyle's sight-based shriek; Mage Hand reaches Barov without a climb. Otherwise climb Athletics DC 12.

Misplacements

Every wrong placement drops ALL placed relics back to the table. On the second and later wrong placements, gargoyle shrieks: DC 12 Wisdom or 1d6 psychic to visible characters. Griffin is never targeted.

Taboo swap: dagger to Barov or crown to Teresa releases Spectre: AC 12, HP 14, +4 to hit, 1d6 necrotic. Warn neutrally before every crown or dagger placement, whether the proposed match is right or wrong. Handling and inspection are safe. An offering to a statue counts as placement; moving a token around the table does not.

DM ONLY — Coaching & emergency clues

Opening

Six stone ancestors wait with empty hands. Six relics lie under a rumpled velvet runner. A stone gargoyle watches. Barov stands on a taller plinth. Do not name professions or announce stains before inspection.

2–3 minutes

“That velvet runner is lumpy. Anyone curious?” Lifting the runner reveals the reading-table inscription; by 3:00 let it slide away if they need help.

5–6 minutes

“Your sheet says you love splitting up. Anything there that fits?” For Griffin: “Barov’s hands are way up there. Anything that reaches?” Give the earned detail slips, not the item answers.

8–9 minutes

Reveal the plinth plate. “Look closely at what isn’t there.” If they have not found it by 9:00, the plate cracks free automatically.

Emergency — only after taboo swap or stuck at 11:00

The ghost librarian whispers: “Give the book to the ink, the scythe to the mud, the hammer to the soot, the spear to the brine, the crown to the spotless one, and the dagger to the blood!”

At 11:00 say only the pairs still missing. At 13:00 give the full line if needed. Open the gate by 15:00.

Protect deduction

Do not confirm guesses until a token is placed. Reward creative inspection. Keep the same warning for correct and incorrect crown/dagger choices. Cap unrelated combat or semantic debates at about a minute, then redirect toward evidence.

Source: Stations/Station_1_Library_Crown_and_Dagger.md. The placement-trigger rule above follows the explicit Failure Consequences section.

STATION 1 HELPER GM — THE LIBRARY (CROWN & DAGGER)

Pair: Fred Jones (Fighter) & Griffin the Invisible Man (Rogue) · **Goal:** place the 6 relics in the right statues' hands → Archive Gate opens → **Crest #1 + Evidence Card E1**. **Target:** 10–15 min. Full rules: `Stations/Station_1_Library_Crown_and_Dagger.md`.

Before the players arrive

- Six statue cards **first-name side up**: 1 Victoria · 2 Alexi · 3 Teresa · 4 Valerius · 5 Borislav · 6 Barov (on a box, he's on a tall plinth). Full titles stay face-down until the solve.
- Six relic tokens (book, scythe, dagger, spear, hammer, crown) **under a cloth "velvet runner"** on the reading table.
- Gargoyle card above the "fireplace"; Spectre standee hidden in your lap.
- **Telling Detail slips 1–6** in your hand, sorted. Envelopes 1–5 in order, Envelope 4 sealed. Phone timer.

Your special job: the Telling Detail slips

- A player inspects a statue → **Investigation DC 13** (Fred +4, Griffin +5). Success: hand over that statue's slip and tuck it under the card.
- Fail: *"Only dust and stone. Try a different approach."* They may retry next turn with a new approach (touch, smell, candle, sleeve). The clue is never locked behind one bad roll.
- **Barov needs no roll.** Any close look (Mage Hand, a climb at Athletics DC 12, or a long stare after Envelope 3) finds *nothing, not even dust* → hand over slip 6.

Station clock

Time	Do this
0:00	Read the Player Introduction aloud. Start the timer.
2:00–3:00	**Envelope 1** when they lift the runner (no roll) or inspect the table (DC 11). Not found by 3:00? The runner slides off by itself.
5:00–6:00	**Envelope 2** (hook prompt) if neither player has used their sheet yet.
8:00–9:00	**Envelope 3** when they inspect a plinth (DC 12). Not found by 9:00? A plinth plate cracks loose: hand it over.
11:00	Stuck, or right after a crown/dagger swap: **Envelope 4**, but speak only the pairs they haven't locked in.
13:00	Still stuck: read all of Envelope 4.
15:00	Lead GM's bell = hard stop. Finish fast, then **Envelope 5** and send them to the Gate.

Answer key (DM eyes only)

Statue	Detail on its slip	Relic
1 Victoria (Arch-Librarian)	Ink on fingertips	**Book**
2 Alexi (the Harvester)	Mud on boots and hem	**Scythe**
3 Teresa (the Traitor)	Crimson-stained hands	**Dagger**
4 Valerius (Admiral)	Salt, brine, barnacles	**Spear**
5 Borislav (Forge-Master)	Soot on jaw and knuckles	**Hammer**
6 Barov (the Spotless)	Nothing at all, not even dust	**Crown**

STATION 1 HELPER GM — RUNNING THE ROOM

Failure rules

- **Placement only:** handling/inspection is safe. An offering to a statue counts; moving a token around the table does not.
- **Any wrong placement:** the statue shudders and *every* relic placed so far clatters back to the table. Sweep them all back yourself, loudly.
- **2nd wrong placement onward:** the gargoyle shrieks at everyone it can see: DC 12 Wis save or 1d6 psychic. **Griffin is invisible and never targeted.** Point that out the first time; he'll love it.
- **Crown ↔ Dagger swap** (dagger to Barov or crown to Teresa): a minor **Spectre** appears (AC 12, 14 HP, +4 to hit, 1d6 necrotic). Fred's Net Trap (DC 13 Dex) plus Griffin's Sneak Attack ends it in about a minute. This unlocks Envelope 4 early.
- **Taboo warning:** before any crown or dagger placement, say *"The gargoyle's eyes flare red. Are you sure?"* Say it **every time, right or wrong**, so it gives nothing away.

Nudges (questions only, never answers)

When	Say
Nobody touches the table (2–3 min)	*"That velvet runner is lumpy. Anyone curious?"*
Guessing, not looking (3–5 min)	*"These are statues of real people. What would a statue remember about the person?"*
Hooks unused (5–6 min)	Fred: *"Your sheet says you love splitting up."* Griffin: *"Barov's hands are way up there. Anything on your sheet that reaches far?"*
Five stains found (8–9 min)	*"What's strange about the sixth statue?"* / *"Have you checked the plinths?"*
Arguing over the rhyme	Give it a minute, then: *"What does a tiller do in a field?"*

Character rulings

- **Fred, "Let's Split Up!"** (station ruling): once here, Fred and his partner inspect two different statues at once, **both with Advantage**.
- **Griffin, "Mage Hand Shenanigans":** inspects Barov's plinth without climbing and can float the crown into Barov's raised hands.
- Accept Fred's **Survival** (mud) or Griffin's **Sleight of Hand** (blood under nails) as inspection rolls on the fitting statues.

Don't

- Don't name an item-statue pair or confirm a pairing before the token is placed. "Try it and see" is fine.
- Don't point at Barov or call him spotless before Envelope 3.
- Don't read the full statue titles aloud or let players see this card.
- Don't open Envelope 4 early because the table is noisy.

Reward (Envelope 5)

Flip the statue cards to show the full titles, then hand over **Crest #1** and **Evidence Card E1**. Say: *"Take these to the Grand Gate. Hurry!"*

STATION 1 — ENVELOPE LABELS (TAPE ONE TO THE FRONT OF EACH ENVELOPE)

ENVELOPE 1 · LOOK AROUND

Station 1 · Library. Open at **2–3 min**, or when they lift the runner.

ENVELOPE 2 · YOUR SHEET

Station 1 · Library. Open at **5–6 min** if hooks are unused.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE RULE

Station 1 · Library. Open on a plinth search (DC 12), or at **9:00**.

ENVELOPE 4 · SEALED: EMERGENCY

Station 1 · Library. **Helper only.** At 11:00 if stuck, or after a crown/dagger swap.

ENVELOPE 5 · REWARD

Station 1 · Library. Open on solve: **Crest #1 + Evidence Card E1**.

ENVELOPE CONTENTS (CUT OUT AND PUT INSIDE)

ENVELOPE 1 · THE READING TABLE INSCRIPTION

Hand this to the players.

> "Six walked before the master.
> The scholar reads while the tiller reaps;
> the smith burns while the sailor weeps.
> The killer's hands are scarlet stained,
> while one sits clean above the pain."

ENVELOPE 2 · HOOK PROMPT (READ ALOUD)

> Fred: "Your sheet says you love splitting up. What if you both checked different statues at the same time?"
> Griffin: "Barov's plinth is way too tall to climb easily... but something on your sheet can reach six squares."

Ruling: Let's Split Up = both inspect with Advantage this round. Mage Hand = reaches Barov.

ENVELOPE 3 · THE PLINTH PLATE

Hand this to the players.

> I. The hand is marked by what it held.
> II. The hand that never worked shall hold what was never earned.

ENVELOPE 4 · GHOST LIBRARIAN'S WHISPER (READ ALOUD)

At 11:00, speak only the pairs they haven't locked in. Full line at 13:00.

> A translucent librarian floats past, muttering: "Give the book to the ink, the scythe to the mud, the hammer to the soot, the spear to the brine, the crown to the spotless one, and the dagger to the blood!"

ENVELOPE 5 · EVIDENCE CARD E1: THE BORROWED BOOK

Goes in with Crest #1. The players carry it to the Gate.

> Tucked behind Barov's plinth: *Spooky Mechanisms for Beginners*, long overdue. The borrower's signature is smeared from right to left, the way a **left-handed** writer drags their hand through wet ink.